

Roman towns and cities

Wherever the Roman armies conquered, they established towns and cities, extending the empire and, with it, their architectural and engineering achievements. Local materials were used, but common elements prevailed, including straight roads, arched bridges and aqueducts. Roman towns were designed in grids, centring on the crossing of two main roads, one oriented north–south and the other east–west. Where they met, the main buildings and spaces were set up, including the basilica, forum, market, amphitheatre, baths and temple. Dwellings filled the straight streets leading off the main roads. There was also an army barracks in every town, protected by a fortified surrounding wall, while aqueducts provided clean water and a sewage disposal system removed waste. The most well known of these towns and cities are Rome itself, Pompeii and Herculaneum, although Pompeii did not conform to a Roman grid as it had to fit into mountainous terrain. Private houses were typically ‘inward-looking’, opening onto a central courtyard, though many Pompeian houses also had balconies.



Roman ruins at Ostia Antica, Italy